

Stirling Castle - Kids

UK Family Tour

Why This Castle Is So Special

Before we go in, let me tell you what makes this place so special, because Stirling might be the most important castle in all of Scotland.

Here is the big secret. A long time ago, and for hundreds of years, the island we are standing on was not one country. It was two. Down in the south was England, bigger and richer. Up here in the north was Scotland, with its own kings and its own crown. The two countries argued and fought a lot, a bit like two families sharing one island who could not agree where the fence should go.

Now look down from the castle at the flat land below. Long ago that was squishy, muddy swamp, and Stirling guarded the only safe bridge across the river. That meant any army marching through Scotland had to pass right here, underneath these walls. So people said, whoever holds Stirling holds Scotland. If you controlled this rock, you controlled the whole country.

But Stirling is not just a fort with cannons. It was also a royal home, a fancy painted palace where kings and queens lived. A baby queen was even crowned right here. You will hear all about her later. Her name was Mary, Queen of Scots.

In the next few short chapters, I will help you understand who was fighting who, when all this happened, and how one family connects this castle to almost everywhere else on our trip. Then we will go exploring.

Two Countries Sharing One Island

Here is something that surprises a lot of visitors. Today, England and Scotland are part of one country called the United Kingdom. But for a very, very long time, they were two completely separate countries, sharing one island.

Think of it like this. Imagine one big island with a line drawn across the middle. On the bottom half lived the English, with their own king. On the top half lived the Scots, with their own king and their own crown. England was bigger, and had more people and more money. Scotland was smaller, with lots of mountains, which actually made it harder for anyone to conquer.

Sometimes the two sides got along, and their royal families even married each other. But a lot of the time, they fought. Again and again, powerful English kings tried to take over Scotland and rule it themselves. One English king, Edward the First, was so tough on the Scots that they nicknamed him the Hammer of the Scots. He even stole the special stone that Scottish kings sat on to be crowned.

That made the Scots furious, and they fought back. Two brave leaders became heroes for standing up to England. One was William Wallace. The other was Robert the Bruce. You will meet both of them here at Stirling, because this castle was right in the middle of all the fighting.

So whenever you hear about battles and castles today, remember, it is really a story about two countries, sharing one island, who could not stop arguing over who was in charge.

When Did All This Happen?

Old castles can make time feel confusing, so let me help you figure out when everything happened, using things you might already know about.

First, this is all way before phones, cars, and electricity. It is even before Christopher Columbus sailed across the ocean to America. So imagine a world with no engines at all, just horses, swords, and stone castles.

The big battles at Stirling, with William Wallace and Robert the Bruce, happened about seven hundred years ago. That is the time of knights in shining armour, riding horses and fighting with swords and shields. Think of a classic knight at a castle, and you have got the right picture.

The beautiful painted palace here was built later, about five hundred years ago. That was around the same time Columbus was sailing to America, and when famous artists like Leonardo da Vinci were painting in Italy. This is when the baby queen, Mary, was crowned here.

And the very last big battle near this castle happened about two hundred and eighty years ago, when a prince tried to grab back the throne with a Highland army.

So Stirling's story is really long. It stretches all the way from the time of knights to a time much closer to today. That is why this one castle has so many amazing stories. People have been fighting over it, and living in it, for hundreds and hundreds of years.

One Family and a Whole Lot of Castles

Here is a fun thing to notice on our trip. The same royal family keeps popping up, again and again, in different castles and cities. And a lot of them are connected right here at Stirling.

The family were called the Stewarts. They were the kings and queens of Scotland, and this castle was their favourite home. They grew up here, got married here, and raised their own children here, safe behind the strong walls.

The most famous was Mary, Queen of Scots. She became queen when she was just a tiny baby, only a few days old. She was crowned in the chapel here when she was nine months old. Imagine a baby being made queen of a whole country.

Now here is the amazing part. Mary had a son named James. Far away in England, there was a queen called Elizabeth, but she never had any children. So when Elizabeth died, guess who got to be the next king of England? Mary's son, James. He was already King of Scotland, and now he became King of England too. One person, wearing two crowns, joining the two countries together for the first time.

That is why this family shows up everywhere we go, in London, in Edinburgh, and here. If you look at the Royal Family Tree in this app, this is the family it is all about. One big, dramatic, castle hopping family.

The Castle That Was the Key to Scotland

There's an old saying: whoever holds Stirling holds Scotland. Here's why. Look out from the castle walls at the flat land below, called the carse. For centuries, that land was boggy marsh, and Stirling had the lowest safe bridge over the River Forth. Every army marching between the south of Scotland and the Highlands had to squeeze through this exact spot — like the neck of an hourglass — right under this castle's guns. That's why Scotland's two most famous battles happened within sight of these walls. In 1297, William Wallace — you might know him from the movie *Braveheart*, though the movie made up quite a lot — waited until the English army was halfway across the narrow wooden bridge, then attacked, defeating a much bigger force. You can see the Wallace Monument tower on the hill across the valley. Then, in 1314, Robert the Bruce beat the English again at Bannockburn, just south of here, in the battle that won Scotland's independence. The day before the main battle, an English knight spotted Bruce on a small pony, ahead of his army, and charged him with a lance. Bruce waited... sidestepped at the last second... and finished the fight with one axe blow. His commanders scolded him for risking everything. Bruce reportedly just complained that he'd broken his good axe.

Related listening: Scotland's two great fortress rocks, contested in the same wars. Listen back — “The Most Attacked Castle in Britain” (Edinburgh Castle, Day 9).

The Trap at Stirling Bridge

Let me tell you exactly how a small Scottish army beat a huge English one, right down there below the castle. Look for the winding river and imagine, instead of the stone bridge you see today, a narrow wooden one, so skinny that only two horses could cross it side by side. In the year 1297, an English army came marching to that bridge. Waiting on the far side, up on the wooded hill where the tall Wallace Monument now stands, were two Scottish leaders. One was William Wallace. The other you may never have heard of, because history is unfair. His name was Andrew Moray, and he was just as clever as Wallace, maybe cleverer.

Here was their plan, and it was beautifully simple. A bridge lets soldiers across only a few at a time, like sand trickling through the neck of an hourglass. So the Scots waited. They watched the English tramp across, slowly, slowly. They did not panic. They did not charge too early. And when about half the enemy had crossed, and half was still stuck on the other side, the Scots came roaring down the hill and seized the end of the bridge. Now the English army was cut in two. The half that had crossed was trapped in a bend of the river with no way back, and the half still waiting could only stand and watch their friends being beaten. They could not help. The bridge was blocked.

One of the men who died that day was an Englishman named Hugh de Cressingham, a tax collector so greedy and so hated that when the battle was over, the story goes, the Scots peeled off his skin and cut it into strips to keep as souvenirs. Yuck, and also, that is how much they disliked their taxes.

Here is the sad part. Andrew Moray, the clever co-leader, was badly wounded in the battle and died a few weeks later. Because he did not live to fight more battles, most people forgot him, and remembered only Wallace. So next time you hear the name William Wallace, whisper Andrew Moray too. He helped win the trap at the river, the day a bridge became the deadliest weapon in Scotland.

Bannockburn and the Castle on a Volcano

Now look south, to the flatter ground with the little stream running through it. That is Bannockburn, where in the summer of 1314 Robert the Bruce fought the biggest army England had ever sent north, and

won. Here is how you beat a giant. You do not meet him where he is strong. You choose the ground.

Bruce picked soft, boggy land, criss-crossed by streams, exactly the sort of place where heavy warhorses sink and stumble. Then his men did something sneaky. The night before, they dug hundreds of hidden pits in the ground and covered them with sticks and grass, little traps for galloping horses to break their legs in. And when the fighting came, the Scots stood shoulder to shoulder in huge circles bristling with long spears, pointing out in every direction like a giant hedgehog. These formations had a name, the schiltrons. A charging horse will not run onto a wall of spear points. It just will not. So the English cavalry crashed and milled about and got squeezed backward, tighter and tighter, into the boggy streams, until the whole enormous army was jammed together and beaten.

The English king, Edward the Second, ran for his life, and here is the delicious part. He galloped straight to this castle, Stirling, hammering to be let in. And the man in charge of the castle said no. He would not open the gate, because the castle was about to be handed over to the Scots anyway. Imagine being a king, chased off a battlefield, and having the door shut in your face by your own side.

Now, one more thing to know about where you are standing. This whole castle sits on top of a volcano. Don't worry, it went cold and dead millions and millions of years ago. Long, long afterwards, giant sheets of ice, glaciers, scraped across the land and wore everything soft down to mud, but they could not chew through the hard old lump of volcanic rock. So it was left sticking up, a steep crag with a long slope trailing behind it, the perfect place to build a fortress you could see enemies coming from for miles. That is exactly why so many people fought over it. This castle was captured and lost, then captured and lost again, over and over, because whoever held this rock held the key to Scotland.

A Painted Palace and the Kingdom of Unicorns

Most old castles are grey and bare, but Stirling shows you what castles really looked like — and the answer is: loud. The Royal Palace here has been restored to how it looked in the 1540s, when King James the Fifth built it to impress his French wife. The Great Hall is painted golden yellow on the outside — it's called King's Gold, and you can see it glowing from miles away. That's not a modern mistake; that's the real recipe. Inside the palace, costumed people in Tudor dress will chat with you as if it's still 1546 — ask them anything: what's for dinner, where's the toilet, is the king grumpy today. They will not break character. Now, about unicorns. Look for them everywhere: carved, painted, and woven into the huge tapestries of the Hunt of the Unicorn, which took weavers fourteen years to recreate by hand. The unicorn is Scotland's national animal — chosen because legend said the unicorn was proud, brave, and impossible to tame. And its enemy, in old stories? The lion — the symbol of England. That's the joke built into the choice. To this day, the royal coat of arms shows a lion and a unicorn holding the shield together: England and Scotland, ancient rivals, stuck on the same team. The unicorn wears a chain. Scots will tell you: only a chain could hold it.

The Faces in the Ceiling

Go into the King's rooms in the palace and look straight up. The ceiling is covered in giant round carvings of oak wood, each one about as wide as a beach ball, and each one is a face. Kings and queens. Roman emperors from thousands of years ago. Brave heroes from old stories. And, hidden among all the important people, a couple of jokers and jesters, the funny men of the court, pulling faces down at you forever. These wooden portraits are called the Stirling Heads, and they are so precious that people sometimes call them Scotland's other crown jewels.

Now here is the wild part, the true adventure story of the faces. Long ago, in the year 1777, the old ceiling suddenly cracked and came crashing down. The heads were rescued, but then something strange happened. Nobody realized how special they were, so they got scattered all over the place. Some ended up as decorations in people's gardens, sitting outside in the rain. One of them, the story goes, was used as the lid on a butter churn, the machine for making butter. Imagine that. A carved royal face, five hundred years old, being plonked on top of the butter.

For years the heads were lost and forgotten, spread far and wide. Then, slowly, like detectives following clues, people began to track them down and gather them back together, one face at a time. Out of the whole set, they managed to find most of them again, and you can go and meet those very originals in a gallery upstairs. The ones you see up on the ceiling are fresh copies, newly carved and painted in bright colors, so you can see how dazzling the room looked when it was brand new.

That is the big surprise about this whole castle. We think of old places as grey and dusty and quiet. But five hundred years ago, this palace absolutely blazed with color, gold and red and blue and green, everywhere you looked, all designed to make your jaw drop. As you walk through, play a game. Look up in every room. Count the faces staring back at you, and try to guess which ones are the kings, and which ones are the fools who were paid to be funny.

The Golden Hall and the Busy Kitchens

Find the huge building painted glowing yellow gold. That is the Great Hall, and it is the biggest room of its kind in all of Scotland. Step inside and look up again, because the roof is the real wonder. It is made entirely of oak beams, curving up into the dark like the ribs of an enormous upside-down ship, and it was

built without a single supporting pillar in the middle to get in the way. When people first walked in here, that soaring empty roof was meant to make them gasp, and it still works.

This hall was a party room, a place for kings to throw feasts so grand that other kings would hear about them and feel jealous. There were four gigantic fireplaces to keep it warm, tall windows to let the light pour in, and space for hundreds of guests. And that golden color on the outside, called King's Gold, is not a modern mistake. Builders mixed a paint from lime and a yellowish earth, and painted the whole hall that bright glowing shade on purpose, so that travelers could see it gleaming from far across the valley and know that a rich and powerful king lived here. It was like a giant sign saying, look how important I am.

Now, a feast that huge needs a lot of cooking, so go and find the Great Kitchens. This is one of the best bits of the whole castle, because it has been set up to look exactly like a busy day five hundred years ago. There are model cooks everywhere, frozen in the middle of their work. One is plucking a bird. One is stirring an enormous pot. One is hauling a whole deer or a great fish to be roasted. There are baskets piled with pretend food, loaves and eggs and vegetables and slabs of meat, all waiting for a banquet that will now never quite be served.

Picture the noise and the heat of the real thing. Fires roaring, knives chopping, sweaty cooks shouting, dozens of dishes all needing to be ready at the exact same moment for the king next door in his golden hall. Being a cook here was one of the hottest, hardest, busiest jobs in the whole kingdom. Sniff the air, and imagine the smell of five hundred dinners cooking all at once.

The Statues on the Palace Wall

Step back from the Royal Palace and look up at the outside walls, high up, where the stone is carved. You will see rows of little stone people, each one standing in its own arched nook like a person waiting on a balcony. There are dozens of them, and they are not just there to look pretty. Every single one was chosen to send a message, and the message was, this king is important, so pay attention.

Start with the grandest figure of all. One of these statues is King James the Fifth himself, the man who built the palace, standing there in stone to gaze down on everyone who came to visit, forever. Around him stands a very strange crowd. There are gods and goddesses from ancient Roman stories, like Venus, the goddess of love. There are holy figures, like Saint Michael, the warrior angel who fights with a sword. And along the very top, watching the roofline like guards on duty, stands a whole line of little stone soldiers.

Now here is the surprise, and it turns this into a game. Somewhere up on that wall, mixed right in among the angels and the saints and the gods, there is a carving of the Devil. Yes, the actual Devil, with a wild face and, some say, little horns. Why on earth would a king put the Devil on the outside of his beautiful new palace? Because long ago, carvers liked to show everything all together, the good and the bad, heaven and its opposite, the whole wide world from top to bottom. Putting them all up there was a way of saying that the king stood above all of it, ruling over everything, the light bits and the dark bits too.

So play detective. Walk slowly along the palace and hunt through the stone crowd. See if you can spot chubby little stone babies with wings, and stern soldiers, and gentle goddesses, and somewhere, grinning out at you across five hundred years, the sneaky face of the Devil himself. The carvers who made all these copied their ideas from pictures printed far away in Germany, and once upon a time the whole wall was painted in bright colours, before the wind and the rain slowly washed it back to grey. Imagine it glowing with paint, a wall full of gods and kings and monsters, all showing off at once.

The Story Hidden in the Tapestries

Those enormous woven pictures of the unicorn are not just decorations. They tell a story, in order, like a giant comic strip made entirely out of coloured wool. There are seven of them, and if you follow them one

by one, you can watch the whole tale unfold. So let me tell you what is really happening in them.

In the first one, a group of hunters and their dogs step into a thick green forest, searching for something rare. In the second, they find it. There is the unicorn, kneeling by a stream, dipping its long magic horn into the water. In the old stories, a unicorn's horn could make poisoned water safe again, so all the other animals of the forest have crept out to gather round and drink safely beside it, rabbits and pheasants and a proud lion, all trusting the unicorn. In the next pictures, the hunters chase it, and the unicorn fights back, kicking and leaping, because it is wild and strong and will not be caught by force.

And here is the secret every hunter knew. There was only one way to catch a unicorn. Not with spears, not with dogs. The only thing that could tame it was gentleness. So in one tapestry, a kind young girl sits quietly in a garden, and the wild unicorn, calm at last, comes and lays its head softly in her lap. That is the moment it is finally caught, not by force, but by kindness.

In the last pictures the hunters take the unicorn away, and it looks like a sad ending. But look at the very last tapestry of all. The unicorn is alive again, resting peacefully inside a little round fence full of flowers, as if by magic it simply could not stay gone. Long ago, people looked at that ending, the creature that dies and yet comes back, and it filled them with hope.

Now remember, the ones hanging here are brand new. A team of eighteen weavers, from all over the world, spent thirteen whole years making these by hand, thread by thread by thread, and some of them worked in a little workshop right here inside the castle. Imagine spending years and years weaving one single picture. Go up close and hunt in the background, because the weavers hid hundreds of tiny plants and flowers and animals in the greenery. See how many creatures you can find hiding in the wool.

Peacocks, Swans and the Turnspit Boys

So what did they actually cook in those roaring Great Kitchens, for a king's feast? Not chicken nuggets, I promise you. A royal banquet was as much a show as a meal, and the cooks tried to amaze the guests before anyone even took a bite.

Here is the strangest dish of all. They would take a beautiful bird, a peacock or a swan, roast it fully cooked, and then very carefully dress it back up in its own skin and feathers, so that it arrived at the table looking alive again, tail fanned out in a glorious shimmer, as if it had just strolled onto your plate. There might be a whole boar's head carried in with an apple in its mouth. And then came the sugar sculptures, called subtleties, which were models built out of sugar and almond paste, shaped into castles or ships or lions, just to make the guests gasp. Everything was flavoured with spices carried thousands of miles from faraway lands, spices so rare they were worth almost as much as gold.

Now here is the part I promised would be a little bit yucky, and it is completely true. To roast all that meat, they pushed it onto a long metal rod called a spit and held it over the huge fire. But the meat had to be turned, round and round, slowly and steadily for hours, or one side would burn to charcoal while the other stayed raw. So who turned it? Very often, a boy. A boy no bigger than you.

He was called the turnspit, and it was one of the worst jobs in the whole castle. He sat right beside the blazing fire, close enough to feel it scorch his face, red and sweaty and covered in grease and smoke, cranking the handle round and round and round for hour after hour, and he did not dare stop, because if he did, the king's dinner would be ruined. Some kitchens even trained little dogs to run inside a wheel to turn the spit instead.

Children worked hard in a place like this, fetching water, plucking feathers, scrubbing pots until their hands were raw. So next time you stand among those still, silent model cooks, look down low and see if you can spot the small ones, the kitchen children, and think how lucky you are that your only job today is to stand here and listen to a story.

A Nine-Month-Old Queen and the Man Who Tried to Fly

Two last Stirling stories. First: in 1543, in the Chapel Royal here, Scotland crowned a new monarch — Mary, Queen of Scots. She was nine months old. She cried through the entire ceremony, and since a baby can't hold a scepter or a giant sword, nobles held each item over her while she wailed. She grew up to have one of the most dramatic lives in history — three husbands, prison escapes, secret codes, and a tragic end — but it all started here, with a crying baby in a crown-sized problem. Second, the legend of the flying man. In 1507, an Italian at the Scottish court named John Damian announced he would fly from Stirling Castle's walls to France. He built himself wings from feathers, climbed the battlements before the whole court, jumped. . . and dropped straight into the muck heap below the walls. He survived — with a broken thigh bone — and his excuse was magnificent: he'd used chicken feathers by mistake, he said, and chickens are drawn to the ground, whereas he should have used eagle feathers. The king kept him at court anyway, possibly because he was so entertaining. Look over the walls at the drop and decide for yourself how lucky he was. Then find the Great Kitchens, where model cooks are frozen mid-feast, preparing a banquet that's been almost ready for five hundred years.

Related listening: Mary, Queen of Scots was crowned at Stirling and lies buried in the Abbey. Listen back — “The Church Where Kings Are Crowned” (Westminster Walk, Day 6). Related listening: Mary, Queen of Scots again: crowned at Stirling, at home, and in trouble, at Holyrood. Listen back — “A Castle at One End, a Palace at the Other” (Royal Mile & Old Town, Day 9).

The Flying Abbot and His Wings

Let me tell you the whole story of the man who tried to fly, because it is even better than you think. His name was John Damian, and he came from Italy to work for the King of Scotland, James the Fourth. His real job was not flying. It was something even stranger. He was an alchemist, a kind of magician-scientist who promised he could turn ordinary metal into pure gold. The king loved that idea, obviously, and gave Damian a workshop with roaring furnaces, right here in the castle, where he boiled and mixed and burned things for years, trying to brew a magic liquid that would make everyone rich. It never worked. Not once. But the king kept paying, and paying.

Then, in the year 1507, Damian announced his most daring plan yet. He would build himself a pair of wings and fly, he said, all the way across the sea to France, faster than any messenger could ride. He gathered feathers, strapped on his home-made wings, and climbed up onto the high castle walls while the whole court gathered below to watch. Imagine the crowd, whispering, pointing, half sure he would soar like an eagle.

He jumped. And he dropped like a stone, straight down, and landed with a splat in the midden. Now, a midden is the castle rubbish heap, the place where they threw all the kitchen scraps and, well, the toilet waste too. So he did not just fall. He fell into a giant pile of poo. And he broke his thigh bone, the big bone in his leg.

But here is why we still tell the story. Damian had an excuse ready, and it is magnificent. It was not his fault, he insisted. The problem was the feathers. Some of them, he said, had come from hens, from ordinary chickens, and everyone knows chickens cannot fly and love to scratch about in the dirt. So naturally those feathers had dragged him down into the muck. If only he had used proper eagle feathers, he would have flown to France, no trouble at all.

There was a poet at the court named William Dunbar who thought this was the funniest thing he had

ever seen, and he wrote a mocking poem about it, pretending that all the birds of the sky attacked the flying man and knocked him out of the air. That poem still survives, which means people have been giggling at John Damian for over five hundred years. Look over the wall, spot the long drop, and be very glad you have never landed in a castle midden.

The Baby Prince's Fireworks Party

You already know that a baby was crowned queen in this castle. Well, this castle was also where kings threw the most spectacular baby parties in Scottish history. Not birthday parties. Baptisms, the special ceremony when a baby is welcomed and named. And royal ones were wild.

In the year 1566, the baby prince James, the son of Mary Queen of Scots, was baptized right here. To celebrate, they put on something Scotland had never seen before. Fireworks. Real, whooshing, banging, sparkling fireworks, lighting up the night sky over the castle. It was, as far as anyone can tell, the very first proper firework display in the whole country. Picture the crowds gasping and pointing at the exploding colors, having never in their lives seen anything like it.

That baby James grew up to become king, and years later he threw a baptism party of his own for his little boy, Prince Henry, in the year 1594. And this one may be the most extraordinary feast ever held in that golden Great Hall. When it was time for the fish course, the doors swung open and in came, not a waiter with a tray, but an enormous model sailing ship. It was as long as a bus, eighteen feet, with real masts and rigging soaring high overhead, and it was loaded with all the fish for the feast. And to announce its grand arrival, the little ship fired its cannons. Actual cannons, going bang, indoors, at dinner.

But here is my favorite part, the plan that was almost even crazier. The very first course was meant to be pulled into the hall on a fancy chariot. And do you know what they wanted to pull that chariot? A real, live lion. A genuine lion, harnessed up, hauling a wagon full of food between the tables. Then somebody, thank goodness, stopped and thought about it. What if the lion got frightened by all the noise and the crowds? Or worse, what if the guests got frightened by the lion? So at the last minute they called off the lion and had a person guide the chariot in instead, with the wheels moved by a hidden machine so it seemed to roll along by magic.

So remember, when you stand in that quiet golden hall, that once it was full of fireworks and cannon fire and a ship the size of a bus, and very nearly a lion, all to celebrate one small baby. Kings really did know how to throw a party.

Mary's Great Escape

The baby who cried through her own coronation grew up to have a life so full of danger and adventure that it sounds like a made-up movie, except every bit of it really happened. Her name, of course, was Mary Queen of Scots, and here is what became of her.

When she was still tiny, only five years old, powerful people in England wanted to grab her and marry her off, so to keep her safe her family smuggled her across the sea to France. She grew up there as a French princess, and she grew up tall, nearly six feet, which was like a giant back then, and clever, able to speak five different languages. But when she sailed home to Scotland as a young woman, everything went wrong, one thing after another.

One evening her private secretary was dragged away and murdered right in front of her, while she was expecting a baby. Then her own husband's house was blown up in the middle of the night, and he was found dead in the garden. It was a mystery worthy of a detective story, and Mary was never safe again. Her enemies took away her crown and forced her to hand it to her baby son, that same little James who had the firework party.

Then came her most famous adventure. Mary was locked up as a prisoner in a castle on an island in the middle of a lake. Escape looked impossible. But she made friends with a boy who worked there, got hold of the keys, disguised herself, slipped down to the water, and rowed away across the loch in a little boat in the dark. She was free. She raised a whole army in about a week, though sadly she lost the battle that followed, and fled to England to beg her cousin, Queen Elizabeth, for help.

Elizabeth did not help. Instead she kept Mary a prisoner for nineteen long years. And Mary, being clever to the very end, spent those years sewing beautiful embroidery stitched with secret hidden messages, and sending coded letters smuggled out inside barrels of beer. Sadly, her enemies cracked the code, and that was the end of her story.

But not the end of her family. Her son James grew up to become king of Scotland and England, both at once, the first person ever to rule the two countries together. So the crying baby crowned in this castle became the ancestor of kings and queens right down to today. Every British monarch since is her descendant. Not bad for a girl who once escaped a castle in a rowing boat.

The King, the Earl and the Window

Two days ago, at Edinburgh Castle, you heard a horrible story called the Black Dinner. Do you remember it? Two young brothers from the mighty Douglas family were invited to dine with a little boy who was king. In the middle of the meal, servants carried in a black bull's head, which was an old secret sign meaning death. And then the two Douglas boys were dragged away and killed. A dinner that turned into a trap.

Well, here is the part nobody tells you. That little boy king who sat at the Black Dinner had a name. He was King James the Second. And years later, right here in this very castle, he did something almost exactly the same, except this time he did it with his own two hands.

By now James was grown up, and the Douglas family was still enormously powerful, almost as rich and strong as the king himself, with their own private army of thousands of men. The head of the family, a young man also named William, had made a secret pact with two other powerful lords, a promise that they would all stick together and back each other up no matter what. This frightened the king. A gang of the three mightiest families in Scotland, joined together against him? That was dangerous.

So in the year 1452, King James invited William Douglas here to Stirling Castle for dinner. And to make sure he would come, the king gave him a special royal promise called a safe conduct. It meant, you have my word as king, come and eat with me, and no harm will come to you. Douglas trusted the promise, and came.

They ate together. They talked. And then the king leaned in and demanded, break your secret pact, right now. Douglas looked him in the eye and said no. The king's face went red. He lost his temper completely, pulled out a dagger, and stabbed his own dinner guest. In rushed the king's men, and they finished the terrible deed. And then, the story goes, they carried the earl's body to a window and threw it out, down into the garden below.

To this very day, there is a room in this castle called the Douglas Room, remembering the night a king murdered the guest he had sworn to protect. Two Douglas dinners, in two different castles, twelve years apart, and both of them ended in blood. Whatever you do, if you are ever invited to dinner by a nervous king, you might want to say you are busy.

The End of the Mighty Douglasses

Now, if a king murdered your brother at a dinner party, would you just forgive him and go home quietly? Of course not. And the Douglas family did not either.

The dead earl had brothers, and they were furious. The new head of the family, another James Douglas, came storming to the town of Stirling with a small army. To show the whole world how little the king's promise was worth, he took that royal safe conduct, the piece of paper that was supposed to keep his brother safe, tied it to a horse's tail, and dragged it through the muddy streets while people watched. Then his men set fire to part of the town. It was very nearly all-out war between the king and the most powerful family in the land.

For three years they fought, on and off, castle against castle. But the king had two big advantages. He had other noble families who were jealous of the Douglasses and happy to help bring them down. And he had cannons, the terrifying new weapon of the age, that could knock a castle wall to rubble. Slowly the king squeezed the Douglasses tighter and tighter.

The end came in the year 1455, at a battle called Arkinholm. The king's side crushed the Douglas brothers completely. One brother was killed in the fighting. One was captured and executed. And the last one escaped abroad and never came back. Their great castles were pulled down, their lands were taken away, and their proud name was declared the name of traitors. The family that had once been almost as mighty as kings ended up with nothing at all.

King James the Second had won. But here is the twist at the end. James absolutely loved his cannons, those roaring new machines of war. And just five years later, while he stood beside one of his own giant cannons during another siege, the cannon exploded. It burst apart with a deafening bang, and a flying piece of it struck the king and killed him instantly. The very weapon he loved so much destroyed him. So this castle watched the Douglasses rise as high as the clouds, and then it watched them fall all the way down, one furious dinner and one exploding cannon at a time.

When the Castle Fought Off a Prince

Now jump forward in time, past the kings and queens and the golden feasts. After Scotland and England came to share one royal family, the king and his court packed up and moved away to live in London, far to the south. And this great castle got a whole new job. It stopped being a palace and became a fortress, packed full of soldiers in red coats, guarding the crossroads of Scotland just as it always had.

And in the cold winter of the year 1746, this castle fought its very last battle. A young man called Prince Charles, whom people nicknamed Bonnie Prince Charlie, was marching an army across Scotland, trying to grab back the throne for his family. He swept into the town of Stirling and took it easily. But the castle up on the rock looked down at him and said, in effect, not you, not today.

Inside was a tough old general named Blakeney, well past sixty years old, and he flatly refused to give up. The prince's army did have one supposed expert, a French engineer named Mister Mirabelle, who was meant to be a genius at knocking down castles. But the Scottish soldiers took one look at his work and started mockingly calling him Mister Admirable, as a joke, because he turned out to be rather useless.

His big plan was to haul heavy cannons up onto a nearby hill called Gowan Hill and blast the castle to pieces. There was just one problem. The hill was made of hard rock, so his men could not dig the guns down safely, and he had placed them in a poor spot anyway. When they finally started firing at the castle, the castle's own gunners took careful aim and fired straight back. And in less than half an hour, they had smashed the prince's cannons to bits. After that, nobody dared go anywhere near the ruined guns. It was hopeless.

So the siege simply fell apart. Bonnie Prince Charlie gave up on the castle and marched his army away to the north, toward a final battle at a place called Culloden, a battle he would lose completely. And the old volcano rock, the fortress that had guarded this spot for a thousand years, had quietly won one more time. It never had to fight a battle again.

The Castle Full of Soldiers

After the castle beat off Bonnie Prince Charlie, it stayed a soldiers' home for a very long time, nearly two hundred years. Imagine that. Where kings once feasted and queens were crowned, now ordinary soldiers marched and drilled and slept. This became the home of a famous group of Scottish soldiers called the Argyll and Sutherland Highlanders, and there is still a museum about them inside the castle today, full of medals and old uniforms and drums.

But the soldiers did some things that might make you gasp. Remember that magnificent golden Great Hall, with its soaring wooden roof like the ribs of a ship? The army chopped it up. They built floors across the middle of it and split it into little rooms, turning the grandest hall in Scotland into plain, cramped barracks for the troops. And all those brightly painted walls, the reds and golds and greens that once dazzled everyone? The soldiers slapped plain white paint straight over the top of them until the whole castle was drab and grey and practical.

That sounds like a disaster, doesn't it? A terrible shame. But here is the surprise, the twist that makes this a happy story after all. Being a boring, useful army base is exactly what saved this castle.

Think about it. Because soldiers lived here and needed the place every single day, nobody ever let it crumble into a ruin, and nobody ever knocked it down for its stones, the way so many empty old castles were. And that plain white paint the soldiers splashed everywhere turned out to be like a cosy blanket. It sealed up the beautiful old painted walls underneath and protected them, hidden and safe, for hundreds

of years. Much later, clever experts came along and gently, carefully peeled the white paint back off, and there, waiting underneath, were the original colours, ready to shine again. So when you look at this glowing, golden, restored castle, remember to say a small thank you to the soldiers. Their marching boots and their buckets of dull white paint are a big part of why the palace of the kings is still here for you to visit at all.

Who Really Lived Here?

You have heard about kings and queens, a baby being crowned, a man who tried to fly, and a castle full of cannons. Now let me tell you a different kind of story. Let me tell you about all the other people who lived and worked on this rock, from the fanciest person right down to the poorest, and what an ordinary day was really like for each of them.

Think of the people of long-ago Scotland as a giant ladder. Right at the very top, on the highest rung, stood one single person, the king or the queen. Just below them stood the powerful lords and their clever advisers, the rich and important families who helped run the country. Below them came the skilled workers, the builders and carvers and painters, the people who actually made this castle beautiful with their own hands. And down at the bottom, on the widest rung of all, stood the farmers, ordinary families who grew the food. There were far, far more of them than anyone else.

Here is the interesting part. Every single one of these people was connected to this one castle. The farmer grew the grain, and the grain became the king's bread. The builder carved the stone, and the stone became the king's window. Nobody could manage without the others, not even the king.

So over the next few little stories, we are going to climb up and down that ladder together. We will spend a day as a king, meet a mighty lord, watch the builders sweat, sit down to a poor family's dinner, and finally meet one very interesting person you have not heard about yet. Ready? Let's start climbing.

Being King for a Day

Imagine you wake up one morning and you are the King of Scotland. Sounds brilliant, doesn't it? Well, wait until you hear what your day is actually like.

First surprise. You are never, ever alone. The moment you open your eyes, your room is full of people. Servants help you out of bed. Grown men, important lords, actually argue over who gets to hand you your shirt, because helping to dress the king was a huge honour. You cannot even get dressed by yourself. In fact, you can barely do anything in private, because a king had to be watched, all the time, or people might forget how important he was.

Next you go to church to hear prayers, with beautiful singing echoing all around you, because a king liked music playing almost everywhere he went, like his own personal soundtrack that followed him from room to room.

Then, breakfast. But here is a strange one. Before you are allowed to eat a single bite, someone else has to taste your food first. Why? In case somebody has tried to poison you. Imagine having a taste-tester for your cereal every single morning. Your food arrived on golden plates, sprinkled with spices that had travelled halfway round the world and cost a fortune, while servants knelt down on the floor just to hand you your dinner.

In the afternoon comes the best bit. Hunting. You gallop out on horseback with your dogs and your hawks to chase deer through the forest below the castle. It was exciting, but it was also secretly a way of practising for battle and staying tough and brave.

Now, one king who lived here, James the Fourth, was so curious about everything that he even liked to play at being a dentist. That's right. He would actually pay people to let him yank out their bad teeth. Would you let the king come near your wobbly tooth with a pair of pliers? Yuck.

But being king was not all feasts and fun. Scotland was full of powerful, tough families with their own private armies, and they did not always do as they were told. So the king spent loads of his time riding all over the country, showing his face, sorting out arguments, and reminding everyone who was boss. He had no police and no proper army of his own, just his own cleverness and the respect, or the fear, that he could win from his lords. So even at a grand and glittering feast, a king was always thinking, quietly, in the back of his mind, who really likes me, and who might be plotting against me tonight? Not such an easy job after all, is it?

The Lord Who Guarded the Castle

Right next to the king, on the rung just below, stood the powerful lords. And being a lord was a bit like a wild game of snakes and ladders.

Here is how you could shoot straight up the board. If you were clever, or charming, or really useful, the king might take a liking to you and make you his favourite. Suddenly you would be showered with presents, castles, land, gold, and grand new titles. A person could start out quite ordinary and end up one of the richest people in all of Scotland, just because the king was fond of them.

But watch out for the snakes. Everything you had was really a gift, and a gift can be taken back. If the king changed his mind, or if the other jealous lords decided they hated you, you could tumble right back down to the bottom, and sometimes it was far worse than that. Standing close to a king was exciting, but it could be very dangerous too. In fact, you have already heard what once happened to one unlucky nobleman inside this very castle, at a certain window. Let us just say it did not end well for him.

Now, one family was tied to Stirling more than any other, a family called the Erskines. For hundreds of years, the Erskines had a very special job. They were the keepers of this castle, the ones trusted to guard the rock itself. But they were trusted with something far more precious than stone. They were given the royal babies to look after.

Think about that. If you were the king, and you had a tiny baby son or daughter who would one day rule all of Scotland, where would you keep them safe? You would send them here, to the strongest castle in the land, and you would hand them to the Erskines. Five times over, grandfather to father to son, the Erskines guarded Scotland's royal children. They guarded the little boy who became James the Fifth. They guarded the baby Mary, Queen of Scots. And they guarded the baby who grew up to be James the Sixth. Whoever held the royal baby held the whole future of the country right there in their arms, so it was the greatest honour a family could be given, and an enormous worry too.

If you go down into Stirling town later, look out for a beautiful old ruined building called Mar's Wark. The Erskines built it to show everyone just how important they had become. It is falling to pieces now, with empty windows and no roof, but it is still standing there, quietly showing off, more than five hundred years later.

The Builders and Carvers

Look around at this amazing castle, the carved stone faces, the golden hall, the giant round wooden heads on the ceiling. Now here is a question people almost always forget to ask. Who actually made all of this? Not the king. Kings did not pick up hammers and chisels. It was built by hundreds of ordinary working people, with their own hands, and they are the real heroes of this story.

The most important were the masons, the people who cut and carved the stone. Being a mason was really hard to learn. You started as a young apprentice, sweeping up and watching and fetching, and it took years and years and years of practice before you were allowed to be a proper master. The very best of

them were like artists and inventors rolled into one, able to plan a whole building in their head and then carve the tiniest, most delicate little flower in solid stone.

Here is a cool secret to look for while you are here. When a mason finished cutting a block of stone, he often scratched a tiny secret symbol into it, his own special mark, a bit like signing your name. That was how the boss knew whose work it was, and how much money to pay him. If you look very carefully at old stone walls in Scotland, you can sometimes still spot these little marks, the actual signatures of builders who lived five hundred years ago. Isn't that amazing? Their handwriting is still right here, waiting for you.

And then there were the woodcarvers. Remember those enormous round wooden faces up on the ceiling, the Stirling Heads? We think many of them were carved by a brilliant Frenchman whom the Scots called Andrew Mansioun. He came all the way from France to work for the king, and he was so clever with wood that he could turn his hands to almost anything. He carved fancy furniture, he made bits and pieces for the king's ship, and, sweetest of all, he carved a little wooden cradle for the king's baby. Imagine being so good at your job that the king himself asks you to make the royal cot.

Last of all came the painters, who splashed all that carved stone and wood with bright, glowing colours and shiny gold paint, because remember, none of this was ever meant to be plain and grey. It was meant to dazzle your eyes.

So the next time someone tells you all about the king who built this castle, you can gently put them right. The king did not build it. He just paid for it. The people who really built it were the clever, hard-working hands you almost never hear about. And now, at last, you have met them.

Dinner at the Bottom of the Ladder

Now let us climb all the way down to the very bottom of the ladder, past the king, past the lords, past the builders, right down to the widest step of all, where almost everybody actually lived. These were the farmers, ordinary families who grew the food, and there were far more of them than everyone else put together. Look out from the castle at the flat green fields down below. That rich land is called the Carse, and this is where they worked from morning to night.

Now, imagine walking into a farmer's house for dinner. First thing you notice, it is dark, and it is smoky. Really smoky. Because the fire burns right in the middle of the floor and there is no chimney at all. The smoke just drifts up and leaks out through the straw roof, so your eyes sting and everything smells of woodsmoke. The floor is not wood or stone. It is bare, cold earth. And here is the part that always makes people go eeew. The family very often shares that one single room with their animals. Yes, the cows live indoors with you, right at the other end of the room. Why? Because the cows help keep the house warm, like big furry radiators that moo in the middle of the night.

So what is for dinner? Not much choice, I'm afraid. Almost every single day you eat oats. Oats boiled up into gloopy porridge, oats mixed with hot water into a lumpy grey paste called brose, or oats baked into hard, dry oatcakes. With it you get kale, a tough green cabbage, boiled again and again. And that is more or less it. Meat? Almost never, because the animals are far too precious to eat. And what do you drink, even if you are a child? Weak, watery beer, believe it or not, because the plain water often was not clean or safe.

And here is the hardest part of all. These families did not even own their own fields. They had to hand over a big chunk of everything they grew to the local lord, as rent, plus days and days of unpaid work on his land. They lived very close to the edge, with only just enough to get by from one harvest to the next.

Now remember all those exciting battles you heard about, fought around this castle. Who do you think suffered the most? Not the king, safe behind his thick walls. It was these poor farming families. When

armies came marching past, the soldiers stomped all over the crops, stole the cows, and set fire to the roofs. And if the food you needed for the whole long winter got trampled or burned in a single afternoon, your family might go very, very hungry. The kings fought over the castle. The farmers lost their dinner.

The Woman Who Held the Baby Queen

For our very last story, let me introduce you to one more real person, someone you have definitely never heard of before, even though she once held the most important baby in all of Scotland in her own two arms. Her name was Jean Sinclair, and she was the nurse of Mary, Queen of Scots.

Back in those days, a royal mum did not look after her own baby the way mums do today. Instead, a specially chosen woman did nearly everything, the feeding, the rocking, the cuddling, and staying awake all through the night when the baby cried. That woman was the nurse, and if she did her job well, she became one of the most trusted and best-loved people in the whole palace. Jean Sinclair was so good at it that she had already looked after a royal baby once before Mary was even born. So when the little baby who would be queen came along, everyone agreed. Give her to Jean.

Here is my favourite moment in her whole story. When Mary was just a few months old, a nosy ambassador all the way from England came to check up on her, because there was a rumour going round that the baby queen was weak and sickly. If that rumour turned out to be true, it could change everything. So who sorted it all out? Jean Sinclair. She calmly unwrapped the baby from her tight little blanket and held her up, wriggling, so the man could see with his own two eyes that Mary was a strong, healthy, perfect little girl. And off he trotted to tell everyone the good news. One steady nurse, holding up one baby, and a whole worried country breathed out again.

Soon after that, Jean brought baby Mary here to Stirling, to grow up safe behind these thick castle walls. And later, when Scotland became too dangerous and it was decided to whisk Mary far away to France, guess who went with her, sailing across the whole sea to a strange new country where nobody even spoke the same language? Jean Sinclair. She would not leave her little queen behind, not for anything in the world.

We even still have some of the letters Jean wrote, and they show she was a real person with real worries, especially about money. But she stayed loyal right to the very end, and Mary always remembered her fondly as her darling nurse.

I love finishing with Jean, because think about what she shows us. You did not have to be a king or a lord or a mighty warrior to matter. An ordinary woman, with kind and patient hands, helped keep the future queen of Scotland alive. The kings all get the statues. But people like Jean were the ones who really held the future, sometimes literally, fast asleep in their arms.